FOR COMPLETE BEGINNERS

Wrong Java?

Complete Modern Java, episode 2: install Java 25 and IntelliJ IDEA on a Mac

> Installing a JDK does not change which Java your terminal finds. The path does.

The terminal on this Mac answered java -version with Java 11, from 2022. Java was installed; the wrong one answered.

We installed IntelliJ IDEA, downloaded Java 25 from inside it, typed and ran the receipt program, then made the terminal find Java 25 too.

In this episode

- The JDK and the IDE
- Download JDK in IntelliJ
- Java Compact File and Run
- PATH and JAVA_HOME, for one window

Coming next

- Windows install (its own episode)
- Node and TypeScript (episode 3)
- Making the PATH change permanent (later)

At the time of recording: Java 25 LTS; IntelliJ IDEA core Java free, no sign in.

01 What each check printed

java -version, BEFORE	`openjdk version "11.0.14.1" 2022-02-08 LTS`
type -a java	`java is /usr/bin/java`
java -version, AFTER the fix	`openjdk version "25.0.4.1" 2026-08-18 LTS`
IntelliJ Run	`Sarah's groceries, Items: 3, Total: $3.99, exit code 0`
Project Structure, SDK	`temurin-25`

Run in IntelliJ's terminal on a Mac, 2026-10-18.

02 Java 25 from inside IntelliJ

New Project: name GroceryReceipt, build system IntelliJ, untick Add sample code. JDK: Download JDK, version 25, vendor Eclipse Temurin. The dialog shows where Java will live: note it.

the location IntelliJ showed

```
~/Library/Java/JavaVirtualMachines/temurin-25.0.4.1
```

> Project Structure, SDK: temurin-25
>
> Run on a real Mac, 2026-10-18, in a fresh IntelliJ IDEA with Temurin 25.0.4.1.

03 Make this terminal find Java 25

The terminal runs the first java on its PATH. Point JAVA_HOME at the JDK and put its bin folder first. This lasts for one window.

terminal

```
java -version
type -a java
export JAVA_HOME=$HOME/Library/Java/JavaVirtualMachines/temurin-25.0.4.1/Contents/Home
export PATH="$JAVA_HOME/bin:$PATH"
java -version
java src/GroceryReceipt.java
```

> Before: 11.0.14.1. After: 25.0.4.1. The last command printed the receipt.
>
> Run on a real Mac, 2026-10-18, in a fresh IntelliJ IDEA with Temurin 25.0.4.1.

Three checks prove your setup

1. The program runs in IntelliJ.
2. The terminal says Java 25.
3. java src/GroceryReceipt.java prints the receipt.
4. Project Structure shows the SDK you downloaded.

Everything else

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The code and the steps: complete-modern-java
https://github.com/code-with-sam-dev/complete-modern-java

IntelliJ IDEA: SDKs
https://www.jetbrains.com/help/idea/sdk.html

If this was useful, a like and a subscribe help more than you would think. And tell me in the comments which part of your workflow you want taken apart next.

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